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Longitude Periodicity in the UNESCO World Heritage Corpus: A Spatial Enrichment Test Using the Babylonian Bēru Unit

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ABSTRACT

A one-dimensional angular enrichment test is applied to the UNESCO World Heritage Cultural and Mixed corpus ($N = 1011$) using the 0.1-bēru interval (3°), the smallest integer subdivision of the Babylonian unit (MUL.APIN, c. 1000 BCE). Mount Gerizim (35.269°E) serves as anchor on historical grounds (§6.1). Sites within ≤ 0.002 bēru (∼6.7 km) of a harmonic node are designated Tier-A+. Domed monuments ($N = 90$) show significant A+ enrichment (Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.003$, $k = 3$), and cluster asymmetry independently reaches significance ($p_{\text{adj}} = 0.01$). The anchor is historically motivated; the pipeline is fully reproducible.

1 | Introduction

This study applies a one-dimensional angular enrichment test to the externally curated UNESCO Cultural and Mixed corpus ($N = 1011$), using a reproducible computational pipeline (see Data and Code Availability, §A.2). The approach employs a geometric null with no free parameters and is intended as a reusable framework for spatial pattern-detection studies in archaeological heritage data.

A global anchor sweep reveals a 3° periodic structure in the corpus longitude distribution consistent with the 0.1-beru unit; the full treatment and its methodological implications are in §5.3 and §6.1.

Why this design addresses key methodological criticisms. Prior metrological investigations were rightly criticized for investigator-assembled site lists (Williamson & Bellamy 1983, Freeman 1976, Kendall 1974). Three features distinguish this study: (1) the UNESCO site list was compiled without reference to this hypothesis and is fixed; (2) the 0.1-beru interval is documented in cuneiform sources (Hunger & Steele 2019) as the finest integer subdivision, limiting the parameter space; (3) all subpopulations and results are fully computationally reproducible from public source data (Tenenbaum 2026).

Positioning within quantitative archaeometry. This paper belongs to the tradition of probability-based spatial analysis in archaeometry (Magli 2013 2016, Ruggles 1999 2015, Silva 2020).

2 | Background

2.1 | The Beru Unit

The *beru* (30° of arc) is attested in the MUL.APIN cuneiform compendium (Hunger & Steele 2019, Watson & Horowitz 2011), dated to the late second or early first millennium BCE. The unit divided the ecliptic into twelve segments and served for both stellar and terrestrial angular measurement; the terrestrial use is explicit in MUL.APIN II ii 43–iii 15. The sub-division into 30 *uš* (1 uš = 1°) is well attested (Hunger & Steele 2019, Robson 2008), and the 0.1-beru interval (3°) tested here corresponds to exactly 3 *uš*.

The beru also functioned as a unit of territorial description: royal inscriptions record inter-regional distances in beru, *kudurru*

(boundary stones) recording territorial extents were deposited in temples as legally authoritative records (Robson 2008, Powell 1987), and the Babylonian *Imago Mundi* marks distances beyond the Salt Sea as beru multiples. Systematic meridian transit observation and eclipse timing, both attested in the cuneiform record (Hunger & Steele 2019, Neugebauer 1975), are sufficient to derive inter-site angular separations at 1° resolution; the gnomon, attested across Mesopotamian, Egyptian, and Indian traditions (Neugebauer 1975, Shamasastry 1915), provides an independent means of establishing true meridian. This combination provides the documentary basis for the hypothesis; the causal question of precisely how or why this unit is applied is outside scope.

2.2 | Ancient Metrology and Geodetic Practice

Whether pre-modern societies employed standardized angular measures across large geographic scales has a long and contested history. Thom's "megalithic yard" (Thom 1967 1971 1964) stimulated statistical refinement (Kendall 1974) and methodological critique (Freeman 1976). Powell's treatment of Mesopotamian metrology (Powell 1987) remains the standard reference. More recently, Magli (Magli 2013 2016) has applied Monte Carlo methods to archaeoastronomical alignments, and Ruggles and Silva have advanced probability-based frameworks for evaluating orientation claims (Ruggles 1999 2015, Silva 2020). The ICOMOS-IAU thematic study (Ruggles & Cotte 2010) provides institutional context for archaeoastronomical analysis of World Heritage properties. Medieval cartographic traditions also employed directional reference systems anchored to sacred geography, with Jerusalem and Mecca serving as orienting meridians in mappamundi and qibla charts (Harvey 1987), providing historical context for the Levantine corridor hypothesis.

This study departs from prior work in three respects: the site list is externally curated (UNESCO World Heritage), eliminating selection bias; the test is one-dimensional (longitude only), yielding a well-defined geometric null (4%) with no free parameters; and the analysis is fully computational and publicly archived (Tenenbaum 2026).

2.3 | The Anchor: Mount Gerizim

Mount Gerizim (35.269°E) is the primary reference anchor because of its documented *tabbur ha-aretz* ("navel of the earth") role in Samaritan cosmographic tradition (Purvis 1968, MacDonald 1964, Crown 1989), analogous to Babylon's meridian in cuneiform astronomical records (Hunger & Steele 2019). As a prominent mountain (881 m) in the central highlands, it would have served as a natural survey reference point. No optimization across alternative Levantine anchors was performed.

Gerizim's tentative-list coordinate (ref. 5706, DMS E35 16 08) is externally sourced and does not appear in the UNESCO inscribed corpus (UNESCO World Heritage Centre, Tentative List ref. 5706, State of Palestine, submitted 02 April 2012; archived at https://whc.unesco.org/en/tentativelists/5706/). Jerusalem (35.2317°E), approximately 4.1 km east of Gerizim, is an inscribed corpus member. It is self-excluded when used as anchor and produces the same A+ count (§5.3). Both lie within the *Levantine corridor* (∼35°E, Jordan Valley to Levant), and the enrichment belongs to this corridor, not to the specific anchor within it. Mecca reaches only $p \approx 0.057$ (ns); Mt. Meru (Tanzania, 36.750°E) reaches $p \approx 0.305$ (ns) and Mt. Kailash, the most cited geographic candidate for the cosmological axis mundi, reaches $p \approx 0.206$ (ns). Neither alternative anchor approaches significance.

3 | Data and Methods

3.1 | Corpus Construction

The UNESCO World Heritage XML dataset contains 1248 inscribed nominations across all categories. Two outcome-blind filters yield the analysis corpus: (1) Natural-only sites are excluded (−235, retaining Cultural and Mixed); (2) entries lacking geocoordinates are excluded (−2). The result is $N = 1011$ sites with valid longitudes.

3.2 | Geodetic Framework

The reference anchor is Mount Gerizim at 35.269°E, from Palestine's UNESCO tentative list (ref. 5706, 2012; see §2.3). Gerizim is not on the inscribed World Heritage List and therefore does not appear in the standard corpus. Jerusalem is an inscribed corpus member, scored as a regular site in Tests 1–4 (A+ at 4.1 km under Gerizim). For the anchor-comparison audit and both sensitivity sweeps (§5.3), Gerizim is added as a synthetic corpus entry so that each anchor can self-exclude symmetrically: Gerizim removes itself and tests against the $N = 1011$ inscribed sites (including Jerusalem); Jerusalem removes itself and tests against the same N (now including Gerizim).

For a site at longitude λ, the beru-distance is $B = |\lambda - 35.269|/30$ and the beru-deviation from the nearest 0.1-beru harmonic is $\delta = |B - \mathrm{round}(B, 0.1)|$. The tier classification is a fixed angular criterion. Kilometer labels (e.g. $\lesssim 6.7$ km for Tier-A+) are equatorial approximations computed as $\delta \times 30 \times 111$ km/°, becoming smaller at higher latitudes. This makes the angular criterion *conservative* at high latitudes. A geodesic sensitivity check confirms that applying a strict physical threshold would increase the A+ count to 70, strengthening all primary results. No latitude correction is applied.

The geometric null for Tier-A+ is $2 \times 0.002/0.1 = 4\%$, assuming uniform longitudes. This serves as a convenient reference, but the primary tests are simulation-based null models (§5.5) that preserve the empirical longitude distribution. A Gaussian KDE produces 40.4 ± 6.2 expected A+ (∼4.0%), confirming the geometric null is not materially inflated by longitude clumping.

3.3 | Metrological Basis for the 0.1-Beru Spacing

The harmonic spacing tested is 0.1 beru (3°), the smallest integer sub-division of the beru attested in cuneiform metrology, equalling exactly 3 *uš* (Hunger & Steele 2019, Robson 2008, Powell 1987). It was selected because it is the finest metrologically attested integer sub-division that yields a tractable test (120 harmonics, 4% geometric null). Coarser spacings (0.5 beru, 1 beru) are uninformative; finer sub-divisions (0.02 beru) do not produce the signal (Table 7). No spacing was selected post-hoc.

The 0.05-beru spacing (6°) also reaches significance (Table 7). This is structurally expected because every 0.10-beru harmonic is

also a 0.05-beru harmonic, making the 0.05-beru result a coarser sub-sampling of the same periodicity, not a separate signal.

3.4 | Tier Classification

Sites are classified by δ, the angular deviation from the nearest 0.1-beru harmonic. All tier boundaries were fixed on metrological grounds, not tuned to the data. **Tier A++**: $\delta \leq 0.0002$ beru ($\lesssim 0.67$ km), $P_0 = 0.4\%$, descriptive only. **Tier A+**: $\delta \leq 0.002$ beru ($\lesssim 6.7$ km), $P_0 = 4\%$ (i.e. 2×0.002/0.1), primary threshold. **Tier A**: $\delta \leq 0.010$ beru ($\lesssim 33$ km), $P_0 = 20\%$. **Tier B**: middle zone — neither near a harmonic nor near a midpoint. The C-band is the symmetric mirror of the A-band, measured as $\delta_{\text{mid}} = 0.050 - \delta$ (distance from the nearest inter-harmonic midpoint rather than from the nearest harmonic): **Tier C**: $\delta_{\text{mid}} \leq 0.010$ beru ($\lesssim 33$ km), $P_0 = 20\%$. **Tier C−**: $\delta_{\text{mid}} \leq 0.002$ beru ($\lesssim 6.7$ km), $P_0 = 4\%$. **Tier C−−**: $\delta_{\text{mid}} \leq 0.0002$ beru ($\lesssim 0.67$ km), $P_0 = 0.4\%$, descriptive only. C-band tiers are defined here; their motivation is in §4.1.

3.5 | Test Populations

Keyword populations are approximate; the raw sweep tolerates known false positives while the context-validated variant (Test 2x) applies sentence-level gating for greater precision. Both populations are reported.

Test 1 (full corpus, primary). Full corpus ($N = 1011$), no keyword filter; binomial test of whether the global A+ rate exceeds the 4% geometric null.

Test 2 (dome/spherical, primary). 7 morphological keywords from four roots (*stupa/stupas*, *tholos*, *dome/domed/domes*, *spherical*) are matched as whole words against each site's name, XML description, and extended OUV text ($N = 90$). This raw sweep is over-inclusive: it admits sites where the keyword refers to geological or vernacular features rather than monumental architecture. The context-validated population ($N = 83$) is reported alongside all primary results; it yields stronger significance, consistent with the rejected sites being non-architectural false positives.

Test 2b (mound evolution, sensitivity variant). Extends Test 2 by adding earthen mound-stage keywords (*tumulus, tumuli, barrow, barrows, kofun*). Not counted separately in the Bonferroni family.

Test 3 (cluster asymmetry, primary). Full corpus ($N = 1011$), no keyword filter; tests whether A+ harmonics host more total sites than non-A+ harmonics, independent of any morphological keyword.

Test 4 (temporal gradient, descriptive). Cochran-Armitage trend test on the full corpus based on year of inscription into the UNESCO corpus, no keyword filter.

Test 5 (founding classifier, post-hoc). A context-aware keyword classifier (`lib/founding_filter.py`) refined after initial data inspection to reduce false positives in population construction, with residual interpretive ambiguity and some false positives accepted (Appendix A.2). It addresses what kinds of sites beyond domed monuments tend to fall on harmonic nodes, but carries no weight in the primary evidential chain.

3.6 | Multiple-Comparisons Protocol

Primary test family ($k = 3$).

- **Test 1** (full corpus, $N = 1011$): global enrichment above 4% null.
- **Test 2** (domed/spherical monuments, $N = 90$): morphological sub-population enriched above 4% null.
- **Test 3** (cluster asymmetry, full corpus, no keyword filter): A+-bearing harmonics host more total sites.

Tests 2 and 3 address structurally different questions on different populations and carry the primary evidential weight; Test 1 provides the corpus-level backdrop within the same family. All three pass the Bonferroni bound at $k = 3$ (full corpus $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.031$ *, dome $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.003$ ***, cluster $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.01$ **).

Other tests. Test 4 (temporal gradient, Cochran-Armitage) is descriptive context; the trend is substantially explained by regional composition (§4.5) and is not part of the primary family. Test 2b is a sensitivity variant of Test 2. Test 5 (founding classifier) is post-hoc (Appendix A.2). Test B (Rayleigh, §4.4) is a structural description of the A+ phase-lock that is tautological by construction and is not included in either table.

Results of all primary and secondary tests are consolidated in Table 1.

A comprehensive FDR audit (Benjamini-Hochberg, 45 tests, Benjamini & Hochberg 1995) retains 26 at $q < 0.05$, of which 6 survive Bonferroni at $k = 45$. All three primary results (Tests 1–3) survive FDR correction; Tests 2 and 3 additionally survive full-k Bonferroni. Test 1 passes $k = 3$ ($p_{\text{adj}} = 0.031$) but not full-k. Test B is excluded by construction. The 6 surviving full-k Bonferroni are: domed/spherical A+ enrichment (Test 2, $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.0425$); harmonic-level Mann–Whitney ($p = 0.0000$); sequential-peak permutation ($p = 0.00025926$); corridor occupancy 17/17 and Fisher combined ($p = 1.7 \times 10^{-24}$; $p = 1.5 \times 10^{-19}$); and evolution combined A+ ($p = 0.0005$). The full audit is in the archived repository (Tenenbaum 2026).

3.7 | Null Models

Three simulation approaches (code: `simulation_null_model.py`, 100,000 trials each) and two dedicated geographic-concentration nulls are described with their results in §5.5.

4 | Results

Subsections follow test numbering (Test 1, 2, 2b, 3, 4, 5).

4.1 | Global Enrichment (Test 1, Primary)

The full UNESCO Cultural/Mixed corpus ($N = 1011$) shows a Tier-A+ rate of 5.5% (Figure 1) (56/1011; Clopper-Pearson 95% CI [4.2%, 7.1%]), above the 4% null (binomial $p = 0.0103$; Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.031$, $k = 3$). The signal belongs to the ~35°E corridor, not to either anchor individually (§5.3). The full-corpus enrichment ratio (1.38×) is modest compared to the dome (3.06×) and cluster

TABLE 1 | Multiple-comparisons summary. Primary test family: Tests 1–3 ($k = 3$, $\alpha = 0.05/3$).

Test	N	Raw p	p_{adj}, k=3	Status
Test 1 (full corpus)	1011	0.0103[a]	0.031 *	**Primary**
Test 2 (dome A+)	90	0.0009[a]	0.003 ***	**Primary**
Test 3 (cluster asym.)	1011	0.0033[b]	0.01 **	**Primary**
Test 4 (temporal)	1011	0.0481[b]	—	Descriptive
Test 2b (mound evol.)	110	0.0005[a]	N/A	Sensitivity
Test 5 (founding)	1011	0.009[a]	N/A	Post-hoc

[a]Exact binomial p (one-tailed vs. geometric null); [b]permutation p.

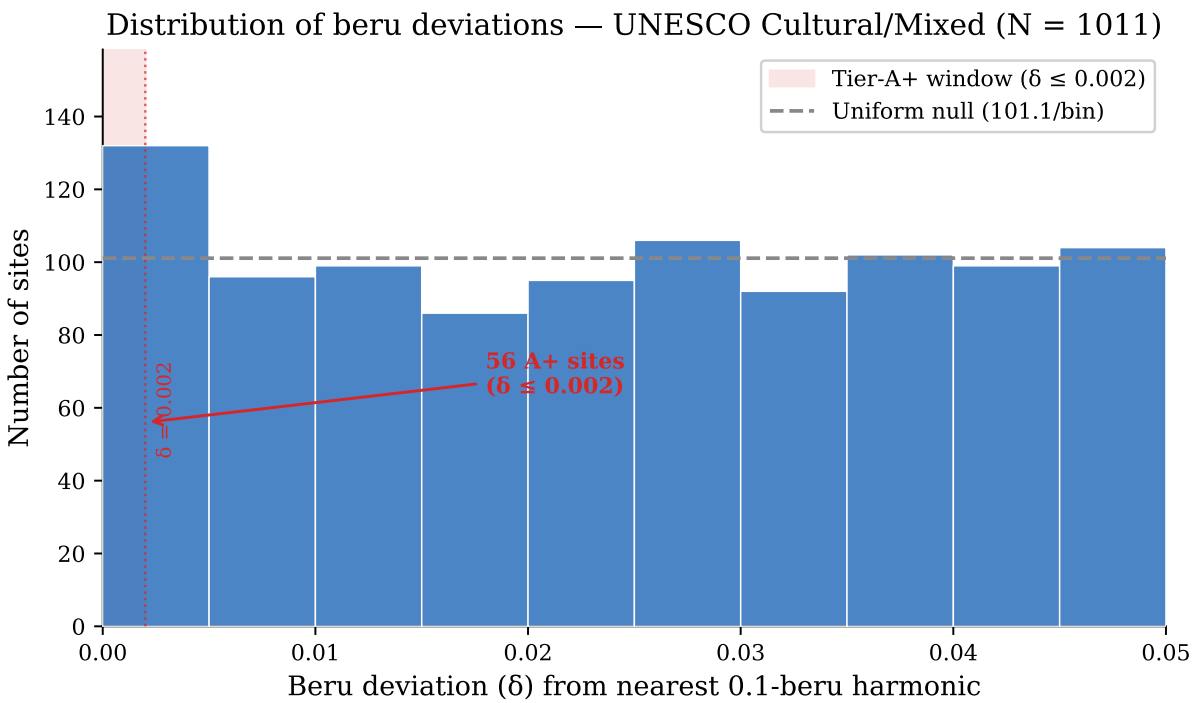

FIGURE 1 | Distribution of beru deviations for the full UNESCO corpus. The excess of sites within the Tier-A+ window ($\delta \leq 0.002$ beru, shaded) above the uniform null (dashed line) establishes the corpus-level signal against which Tests 2 and 3 demonstrate morphological and spatial specificity.

asymmetry results, consistent with only a fraction of sites driving the periodicity.

Region-stratified robustness. A region-specific empirical null test (Fisher combination of per-region binomials) yields $p = 0.8230$ (ns; pre-2000: $p = 0.4205$, ns): when each region's own A+ rate is the null, the stratified signal does not reach significance. The pre-2000 cohort remains significant against the geometric null ($p = 0.0041$ **); see Test 4 (§4.5) for the full region-adjusted analysis.

World religion sites

Religion-keyword sub-populations show consistent enrichment directionality (religion-name matching only). Sites associated with any world religion ($N = 363$): 6.1% A+ (1.52×, $p = 0.0369$, *). Christianity ($N = 219$): 6.8% A+, $p = 0.0312$, *. Buddhism ($N = 46$): 8.7% A+ ($p = 0.1113$, ns). Judaism ($N = 15$): 9/15 sites (60.0%) fall within Tier A ($\leq$ 33 km), compared to 5.32× the rate in the remainder of the corpus (Fisher exact $p = 0.0018$, **). The A-tier signal in the Judaism sub-corpus is concentrated in the outer A-band (7–33 km) and is susceptible to geographic concentration.

Buddhist bimodal distribution

The following is exploratory (FDR-registered, outside the primary family). Among religion sub-populations ($N \geq 10$), Buddhism ($N = 46$) ranks first in *both* the A+ rate (8.7%) and the C-band rate (28.3%, 1.41× the 20.1% baseline). The joint probability of leading both simultaneously is $p = 0.0197$ (exact multivariate hypergeometric; the two bands are mutually exclusive). The pattern has a geographic axis: Lumbini, birthplace of the Buddha (Coningham et al. 2013), is the tightest Buddhist harmonic hit (Tier A+, ∼0.8 km from the 1.6-beru node), while Nara and Hōryū-ji are the only Buddhist C− sites, each within ∼2–4 km of an inter-harmonic midpoint.

4.2 | Domed and Spherical Monuments (Test 2, Primary)

The keyword filter is described in §3.5 ($N = 90$). Permutation $Z = 3.21$, $p = 0.004$; bootstrap $p = 0.006$ (Table 2).

Tier-A+ sites ($N = 11$, 12.2%, 3.06×, permutation $p = 0.004$, Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.003$, $k = 3$): Khoja Ahmed Yasawi (0.2 km), Boyana Church (0.3 km), Lumbini (0.8 km), Humayun's Tomb (2.0 km), Pyu Ancient Cities (2.3 km), Silk Roads: Chang'an-Tianshan (2.5 km), Trulli of Alberobello (3.6 km), Old City of Jerusalem (4.1 km), Borobudur (4.3 km; Miksic 1990), Kizhi Pogost (5.0 km), Echmiatsin/Zvartnots (6.2 km).

A leave-one-out check confirms no single site drives the result: removing any A+ site yields $N = 89$, A+= 10, $p = 0.0030$. Leave-2-out (worst case across all $\binom{11}{2}$ combinations): $p = 0.0087$. Leave-3-out (worst case): $p = 0.0233$. Code: `dome_leave_k_out.py`.

Context-validated robustness checks (Tests 2x and 2bx). Applying sentence-level architectural confirmation reduces the dome population to $N = 83$ (7 non-architectural false positives rejected; filter detail in Appendix A.1). Test 2x yields $p = 0.0005$, 3.31× enrichment, stronger than the raw sweep, consistent with rejected sites diluting the signal. The extended mound-evolution population (Test 2bx, $N = 110$ with context validation) yields $p = 0.0003$ ***, consistent with Test 2x. Because validation rules were developed after the initial sweep, both variants are excluded from the primary Bonferroni family.

Geographic-concentration null (dedicated simulation). Domed monuments are concentrated in the Eurasian corridor: 77% fall in 20°–120°E versus 41% of the full corpus. Two targeted null models test whether this explains the dome enrichment (code: `dome_geographic_concentration_test.py`, 100,000 trials).

Null A (within-dome bootstrap): Draw $N = 83$ longitudes from the dome sites' own list. Mean = 11.01 A+, $p = 0.5490$ (ns). The dome sites' positions are concentrated near harmonic longitudes.

Null C (restricted geographic draw): Pool all full-corpus sites within $\pm W°$ of any dome site and bootstrap the expected A+ count. The primary window (±5°, $N = 881$) was chosen as a practical compromise: ±2° yields a smaller but still adequate pool ($N = 761$), while ±10° expands the pool to near-corpus size ($N = 967$). Dome sites (11 A+, 12.2%) significantly exceed the broader footprint at all three windows: ±2° ($p = 0.0113$, *); ±5° ($p = 0.0080$, **); ±10° ($p = 0.0077$, **). The result is window-independent.

Reconciliation. Null A confirms that the dome sites' longitude distribution reproduces their enrichment (geographic concentration is necessary). Null C establishes that other monuments at the same longitudes are significantly less enriched (geographic concentration is not sufficient). The residual question is whether the sub-longitude precision of domed monument placement reflects metrological intent or an unmodeled aspect of these civilizations. In the global anchor sweep (§5.3), Gerizim scores 56 A+ (97.2th percentile); Jerusalem scores 57 (98.7th). The meta-keyword test confirms that only 2.4% of 1741 candidate words achieve comparable enrichment.

4.3 | Hemispherical Mound Evolution (Test 2b [Sensitivity Variant])

Extends Test 2 by adding earthen mound-stage keywords (see §3.5); the combined population ($N = 110$) adds 20 mound-stage sites to the core domed/spherical population, with 4 sites matching both keyword sets.

Stage-by-stage breakdown (Table 4):

The combined population ($N = 110$, A+ = 11.8%, $p = 0.0005$ ***; Table 3) is consistent with Test 2. The mound stage does not reach significance (8.3%, $p = 0.2492$, ns). The signal is carried by the stupa (5.56×, $p = 0.0050$ **) and dome sub-stages. Leave-one-out checks confirm stability for all sub-stages.

Stupa geographic-concentration null. Stupa sites are concentrated in South/Southeast Asia (72% in 70°–110°E). Null A (within-stupa bootstrap): $p = 0.5920$ (ns). Null C (restricted ±5° draw): $p = 0.0196$ (*).

4.4 | Cluster Asymmetry (Test 3, Primary)

Full corpus ($N = 1011$), no keyword filter (see §3.5). For each site, count other UNESCO sites within ±0.3° longitude; compare cluster sizes for A+ vs. non-A+ sites (Mann-Whitney U, permutation test). At the harmonic level, compare per-harmonic site counts for A+-bearing vs. non-A+ harmonics.

A+-bearing harmonics host 4.06× more sites on average than non-A+ harmonics ($p < 0.0001$; Table 5). Sites at harmonic nodes cluster more densely than sites at harmonic midpoints (9.85 vs. 5.83 neighbors; 1.69×, $p = 0.0238$).

Subtest: does clustering produce the unit-sensitivity peak? A joint permutation test (50000 iterations, two independent shuffles per trial) asks whether extreme clustering mechanically produces the canonical-unit peak. Of 182 clustering-matched permutations ($p_{\text{cluster}} = 0.0036$), the conditional fraction producing the peak is 0.1209, nearly identical to the unconditional rate of 0.1681. The unit-sensitivity peak and the clustering signal are statistically independent; the primary evidence remains the clustering (Test 3, $p = 0.0033$) and dome enrichment (Test 2, $p = 0.004$).

Methodological note: Rayleigh phase-lock (Test B). The near-perfect Rayleigh R of the A+ sub-sample is a mathematical consequence of the A+ classification criterion (§1) and is reported as a structural description, not independent evidence. Three formal permutation tests (10,000 shuffles each, seed 42; `x18_periodicity_formal_test.py`) address distinct aspects of the periodicity:

Test A (full-corpus Rayleigh, negative control). The full-corpus Rayleigh $R = 0.0224$ ($Z = 1.06$, $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.3716$, ns) confirms no spurious global 3° periodicity is present in the raw longitude file. The signal is concentrated in A+ sites, not a global artifact.

Test B (A+-only Rayleigh, structural). Among the 56 Tier-A+ sites, $R = 0.9972$ (essentially all A+ sites share the same phase modulo 3°; $Z = 14.57$, $p_{\text{perm}} < 0.0001$). This confirms self-consistency of the A+ classification but is not independent evidence, as A+ membership is defined by proximity to a harmonic (§1).

Test C (circular-shift anchor sensitivity). Displacing the anchor by a uniform random offset in [0-, 360-) and recounting A+

TABLE 2 | UNESCO domed/spherical monument test ($N = 90$, raw keyword sweep). Primary evidence against the chance explanation: simulation permutation $Z = 3.21$, $p = 0.004$ (§5.5). Exact binomial results are reference baselines assuming uniform longitude spacing. The non-significant χ^2 is discussed in the text.

Metric	Obs	Exp(H_0)	Rate [95% CI]	Enrich.	p	
Tier-A+ ($\leq$ 0.002 beru)	11	3.6	12.2% [6.3, 20.8]	3.06×	0.0009	***
Tier-A ($\leq$ 0.010 beru)	29	18.0	32.2% [22.8, 42.9]	1.61×	0.0043	**
χ^2-uniform (5 bins, df = 4)	—	—	—	—	0.0732	ns

Expected under H_0: A+ = 4%, A = 20%. CIs are Clopper-Pearson exact.
Tier-B (middle zone): 45 / 90 sites. Mean δ: 0.0220 beru.
*** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, † $p < 0.10$ (trend-level), ns = not significant.

TABLE 3 | Test 2b: hemispherical mound evolution ($N = 110$). Combined tumulus → stupa → dome population.

Metric	Obs	Exp(H_0)	Rate	p	
Tier-A+ ($\leq$ 0.002 beru, $\leq$ 6.7 km)	13	4.16	11.8%	0.0005	***
Tier-A ($\leq$ 0.010 beru, $\leq$ 33 km)	35	20.80	31.8%	0.0023	**

Expected under H_0: A+ = 4%, A = 20%. Enrichment: A+ = 2.95×, A = 1.59×.
*** $p < 0.001$, ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$, † $p < 0.10$, ns = not significant.

TABLE 4 | Tier-A+ enrichment by evolutionary stage. Null rate $P_0 = 4\%$.

Stage	N	A+	Rate	Enrichment	p (binomial)
Mound (tumulus/barrow/kofun)	24	2	8.3%	2.08×	0.2492 ns
Stupa (stupa/stupas)	18	4	22.2%	5.56×	0.0050 **
Dome (dome/tholos/spherical)	75	8	10.7%	2.67×	0.0102 *
Combined	**110**	**13**	**11.8%**	**2.95×**	**0.0005 *** **

Stage N values sum to more than the combined total because 4 sites match keywords from multiple stages and are counted once in the combined row. A+ counts by stage are computed within each stage population independently; a site matching two stages contributes its A+ status to each stage separately, so stage A+ values may not sum to the combined A+ count. The combined A+ total is the count of unique A+ sites across the full Test 2b population ($N = 110$).

TABLE 5 | Cluster asymmetry: A+ vs. non-A+ sites in the full UNESCO corpus ($N = 1011$; cluster radius ±0.3° lon)

Metric	A+ sites	Non-A+ sites	Ratio / Z	p
Mean cluster size (sites within ±0.3° lon)	6.77	5.08	1.33×	
Mann-Whitney U (one-tailed)				0.0182 *
Permutation (10,000 shuffles)			$Z = 2.82$	0.0033 **
Harmonic-level density (all Tier ≤ B sites per 0.1-beru harmonic):				
Harmonics with ≥ 1 A+ site (28)	mean = 29.4 sites			
Harmonics with 0 A+ sites (26)	mean = 7.2 sites		4.06×	< 0.0001 ***

sites yields a null mean of 40.36 vs. the observed 56 ($Z = 2.23$, $p_{\text{perm}} = 0.0287$, *). This is the sole positive test that the enrichment depends on the specific Gerizim anchor rather than geographic concentration alone.

4.5 | Temporal Gradient (Test 4, Descriptive)

The A+ rate is highest in the founding canon (1978–1984: 8.0%, 1.99×, $p = 0.0232$) and dilutes to the null in the modern era (2010–2025: 4.0%, ns).
Cochran-Armitage three-cohort: $Z = -1.664$, $p = 0.0481$ (*); five-cohort: $Z = -1.655$, $p = 0.0489$ (*), one-sided. The founding canon is concentrated in Europe and the Mediterranean. Mantel-Haenszel region-adjusted OR = 1.582 ($p = 0.1101$). The temporal gradient is largely explained by regional composition and is treated as descriptive only.

4.6 | Founding-Origin Classifier (Test 5, Post-Hoc)

The founding-origin classifier assigns each site to one or more of five categories: Founding Capital, Sacred Origin, Founding Monument, Founding Axis, and Ancient Continuous Landscape (filter logic in Appendix A.2). Applied to the full corpus ($N = 1011$), the classifier assigns 296 sites (29.3%) to at least one founding category. Of the 56 A+ sites, 25 (44.6%) carry a founding keyword, compared to 29.3% in the full corpus. Fisher exact test: OR = 2.04, $p = 0.009$ *. Because the classifier was iteratively tuned after data inspection it is treated as post-hoc and carries no weight in the primary evidential chain.

TABLE 6 | Tier-A+ enrichment by UNESCO inscription-year cohort ($N = 1011$ Cultural/Mixed sites). Null rate $P_0 = 4\%$.

Cohort	N	A+	Rate	Enrichment	p (binomial)
1978–1984 (founding canon)	138	11	8.0%	1.99×	0.0232 *
pre-2000 (1978–1999)	501	33	6.6%	1.65×	0.0041 **
2000–2025 (modern era)	510	23	4.5%	1.13×	0.3081 ns
ALL (1978–2025)	1011	56	5.5%	1.38×	0.0103 *
Fisher exact (1978–1984 vs. 2000–2025): OR = 1.83, $p = 0.0844$ (†)					

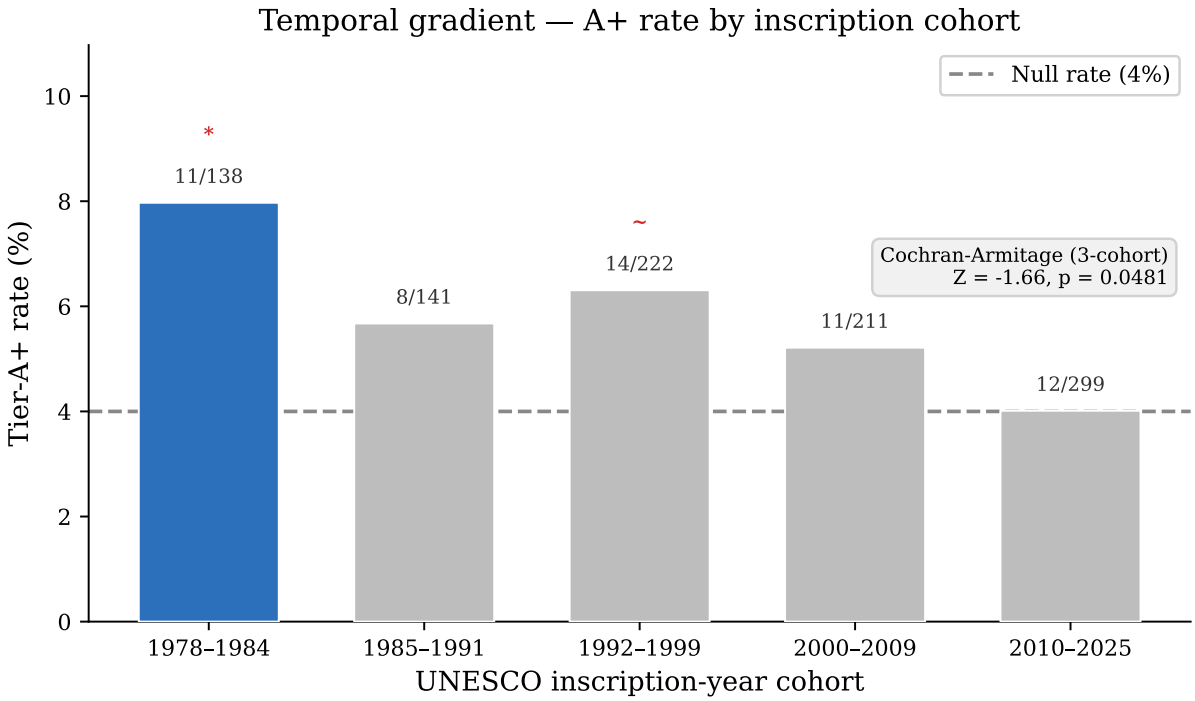

FIGURE 2 | Tier-A+ rate by UNESCO inscription-year cohort.

5 | Robustness Checks

5.1 | Unit Sensitivity Sweep

Varying harmonic spacing from 0.05 to 0.20 beru (physical threshold fixed at 6.7 km), the 0.1-beru spacing produces the strongest joint significance across both the dome and full-corpus populations (Table 7; Figure 3). The 0.05-beru and 0.20-beru spacings also reach significance, as expected structurally: every 0.10-beru harmonic is also a 0.05-beru harmonic ($0.10 = 2 \times 0.05$), and 0.20-beru harmonics are a strict subset. Adjacent non-harmonic spacings (0.06, 0.07, 0.09, 0.11, 0.12 beru) are non-significant in both populations, which is the discriminating observation. The 0.08-beru row reaches nominal dome significance ($p = 0.0229$) but not full-corpus ($p = 0.4371$, ns), reflecting unsystematic local overlap with the 0.10-beru grid.

5.2 | Sensitivity Slope at the Canonical Unit

A fine sweep within ±1% of 0.10 beru (Table 8) shows that a ±0.3% shift collapses joint significance in at least one population; only the canonical value and its immediate neighbor (0.1001 beru) retain dome significance. Two permutation tests (10,000 and 10000 shuffles respectively; code: `sensitivity_slope_permutation_test.py`, `sensitivity_slope_specificity_test.py`) find that geographic concentration alone is sufficient to reproduce both the sharp-peak pattern and the canonical-unit ranking ($p = 0.1728$, ns in both cases). The sensitivity slope therefore provides no independent evidential value beyond Tests 2 and 3.

5.3 | Global Anchor Sweep

A global sweep (0–360°E, 0.01° resolution, 36,000 trial anchors) assesses whether the ∼35°E corridor is unusual globally. The sweep uses the extended corpus described in §3.2 ($N_{\text{ext}} = 1012$): each trial anchor self-excludes any entry within 0.001°, so every focal anchor tests against $N = 1011$.

Both anchors place the corridor in the global top 2.8% (Table 9), and the result is anchor-invariant within the 4.1 km corridor window. The total counts differ by one (56 vs. 57); the extra Jerusalem hit is Mount Gerizim itself at 4.1 km. The A+ compositions diverge more broadly: 18 sites are unique to Gerizim, 19 are unique to Jerusalem, and 38 are shared (supplementary anchor comparison audit). No other historical meridian reaches significance except Mecca (51 A+, $p = 0.057$ †).

TABLE 7 | Unit sensitivity sweep: harmonic spacing varied, physical window fixed at 6.7 km, anchor at Gerizim 35.269°E. Dome column uses the context-validated population ($N_D = 83$; see Test 2x, §A.1). All p-values are one-tailed binomial vs. geometric null at each spacing. The 0.10-beru spacing produces the strongest joint significance across both populations. The 0.05-beru and 0.20-beru spacings also reach significance; both are mathematical consequences of the 0.10-beru structure (every 0.10-beru harmonic is also a 0.05-beru and 0.20-beru harmonic), not independent signals. Non-harmonic adjacent spacings (0.06–0.09, 0.11–0.12) are non-significant. Code: `unit_sweep_fill.py`.

Spacing	Null	Dome hits/N_D	p(Dome)	Full hits/N	p(Full)
0.05	8.0%	12/83	0.0323 *	102/1011	0.0101 *
0.06	6.7%	6/83	0.4799 ns	60/1011	0.8405 ns
0.07	5.7%	8/83	0.1017 ns	55/1011	0.6653 ns
0.08	5.0%	9/83	0.0229 *	52/1011	0.4371 ns
0.09	4.4%	4/83	0.5068 ns	41/1011	0.7466 ns
0.10	**4.0%**	**11/83**	**0.0005 *****	**56/1011**	**0.0103 ***
0.11	3.6%	6/83	0.0820 †	38/1011	0.4407 ns
0.12	3.3%	4/83	0.2997 ns	30/1011	0.7653 ns
0.15	2.7%	6/83	0.0237 *	33/1011	0.1405 ns
0.20	2.0%	8/83	<0.001 ***	28/1011	0.0564 †

TABLE 8 | Fine-grained sensitivity sweep within ±1% of the 0.10-bēru canonical spacing, physical window fixed at 6.7 km. Dome column: context-validated population ($N_D = 83$). Bold row = canonical attested unit. Code: `unit_sweep_fill.py`.

Spacing	Null	Dome hits/N_D	p(Dome)	Full hits/N	p(Full)
0.0990	4.04%	3/83	0.6567 ns	41/1011	0.5124 ns
0.0993	4.03%	5/83	0.2428 ns	47/1011	0.1767 ns
0.0995	4.02%	6/83	0.1174 ns	48/1011	0.1370 ns
0.1000	**4.00%**	**11/83**	**0.0005 *****	**56/1011**	**0.0103 ***
0.1001	4.00%	9/83	0.0059 **	51/1011	0.0563 †
0.1003	3.99%	5/83	0.2366 ns	38/1011	0.6676 ns
0.1010	3.96%	5/83	0.2324 ns	47/1011	0.1490 ns

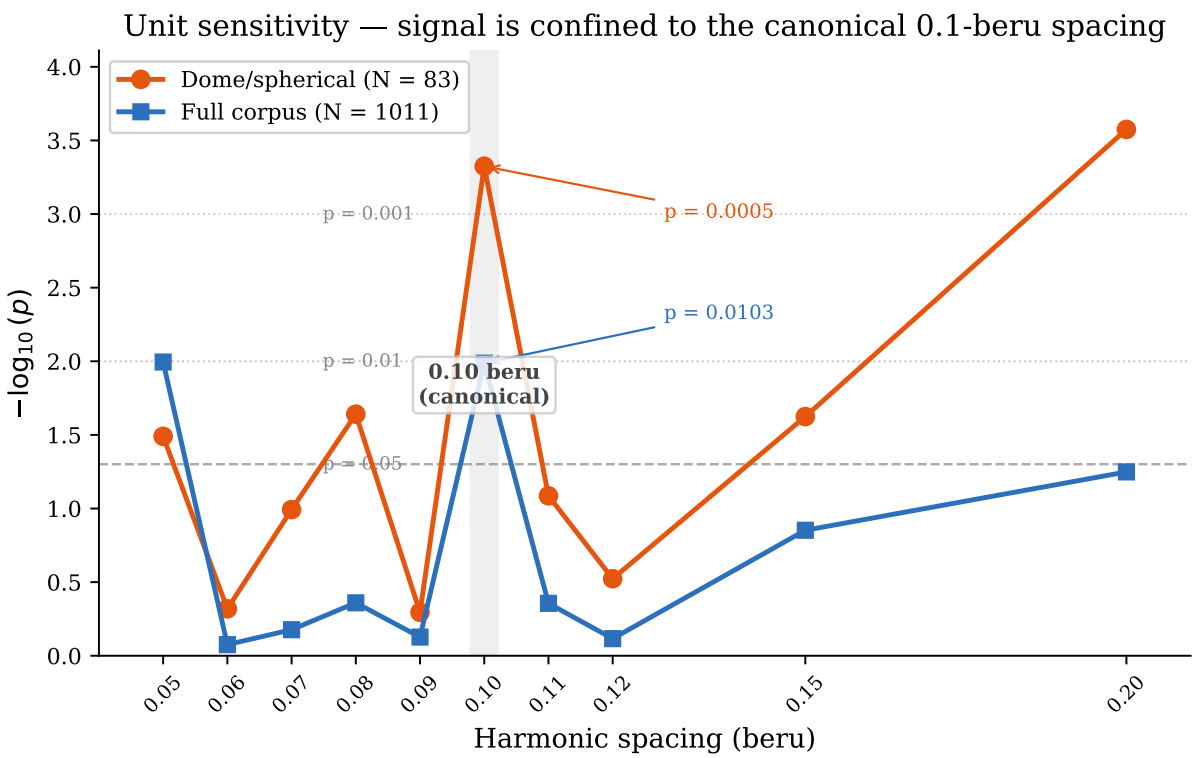

FIGURE 3 | Unit sensitivity: signal concentrated at the canonical 0.1-bēru spacing. Spacings ≥ 0.3% from canonical collapse to non-significance in at least one population.

The x.18°E periodic structure

The most striking result of the global sweep is that every longitude of the form x.18°E (all 120 such anchors) produces identically the maximum A+ count. The spacing between consecutive x.18°E anchors is exactly 3° = 0.1 beru.

The label "x.18°E" is a rounded shorthand for the phase ≈ 2.18° mod 3.0°. Gerizim's phase (35.269 mod 3.0 = 2.269°, gap 0.089° ≈ 8.4 km) is within coordinate uncertainty.

TABLE 9 | Global anchor sweep: both Levantine anchors ranked against the same global distribution. 36,000 trial anchors, 0–360°E at 0.01° resolution; extended corpus $N_{ext} = 1012$ (1011 inscribed + Gerizim synthetic); each focal anchor self-excludes itself ⇒ $N = 1011$. Mean A+ across all anchors: 40.4±6.9.

Anchor	A^{++}	A^{+}	A	Percentile	% anchors ≥
Gerizim (35.269°E)	7	56	228	97.2th	3.99%
Jerusalem (35.2317°E)	7	57	218	98.7th	2.77%

A^{++}≤0.67 km; A^{+}≤6.7 km; A≤33 km. Global max 60 A+ (all x.18°E anchors score identically; §5.3).

Any site near the x.18° phase can serve as a high-scoring anchor. The choice of Gerizim was made on historical grounds (§2.3), and the corridor result is anchor-invariant within the band.

Non-independence note. *The 3° periodicity and the unit sensitivity sweep (§5.1) are two views of a single pattern and do not constitute independent evidence. Neither provides evidential value beyond the dome enrichment (Test 2) and cluster asymmetry (Test 3).*

Two interpretations apply: (1) a global grid with 3° spacing anchored to the ∼35°E corridor would produce exactly this pattern; (2) Eurasian heritage sites cluster in longitude bands that happen to align with the x.18° phase — this cannot be refuted on the UNESCO corpus alone.

Code: `peak_geography_audit.py`, `verify_x18_periodicity.py`.

Formal statistical tests for the x.18° periodicity

Four permutation tests (10,000 shuffles, seed 42; code: `x18_periodicity_formal_test.py`): the full-corpus Rayleigh $R = 0.0224$ ($p_{perm} = 0.3716$, ns) confirms no spurious global periodicity in the raw longitude file. The A+-only Rayleigh ($R = 0.9972$, $p_{perm} = 0.0001$) is structurally expected by the A+ classification criterion and is not independent evidence (§4.4). A circular-shift anchor null recovers only ∼ 40.36 A+ on average versus 56 at Gerizim ($Z = 2.23$, $p_{perm} = 0.0287$, *), providing the only positive evidence that the enrichment depends on the Gerizim anchor rather than geographic concentration; the discovery-corrected max-permutation (Test D) places the sweep optimum within the expected range after accounting for the 36,000-anchor search ($p = 0.2966$, ns).

The dome-periodicity audit (`dome_periodicity_audit.py`) is consistent with beru-alignment but equally consistent with geographic concentration: Gerizim scores at the 100.0th percentile among dome sites, dome site phases are approximately uniform ($\chi^2 = 14.89$, df = 9, $p = 0.0940$, trend-level), and all 11 dome A+ sites have phases within ±0.15° of the x.18° optimal phase. The dome enrichment surviving all three simulation nulls remains the primary evidence against a purely geographic account.

Corridor and landmark ranking. Gerizim (56 A+, $p = 0.0103$) and Jerusalem (57 A+, $p = 0.0070$) both place the ∼35°E corridor in the global top 2.8%. The A+ counts differ by one (Jerusalem finds Gerizim as an extra hit at 4.1 km), but the compositions diverge: 18 A+ sites are unique to Gerizim, 19 are unique to Jerusalem, and 38 are shared. The enrichment belongs to the corridor, not to either anchor individually. Using each UNESCO site as its own anchor, Gerizim ranks #28 of 1012 (top 2.8%). The 35°E corridor leads globally; no other corridor shares a cross-cultural tradition.

5.4 | Spatial Autocorrelation

A+ harmonics host 4.06× as many total UNESCO sites as non-A+ harmonics ($p < 0.0001$). DEFF correction via ICC (±0.5°, $\rho = 0.069$): DEFF = 1.310, $N_{eff} = 772$, corrected $p = 0.020$. Block bootstrap (3° blocks, 100,000 resamples): 95% CI [4.04%, 6.87%] excludes the 4% null. Within-group permutation using UNESCO-region × longitude bins reproduced the observed A+ count exactly in every trial, confirming this test cannot discriminate alignment from geographic concentration; the Null A and Null C simulations (§4.2) address that question directly.

5.5 | Null Model Validation

Three simulation nulls (100,000 trials each, seed = 42, Good 2005): (1) Longitude permutation: dome ($N = 83$) $p_{perm} = 0.004$ (**); canon ($N = 138$) $p = 0.127$ (ns); pre-2000 ($N = 501$) $p = 0.094$ (†). (2) Bootstrap from full corpus: dome $p_{boot} = 0.006$ (*). (3) KDE-smoothed null: expected 40.4±6.2, observed 56, $Z = 2.50$, $p = 0.010$ (*). Dome enrichment survives all three models. The geographic-concentration nulls (Null A, Null C; §4.2) show that proximity to harmonic longitudes is necessary but not sufficient to explain the dome enrichment.

5.6 | Pipeline Portability: Wikidata Q180987 Stupa Corpus

The pipeline was applied to $N = 229$ Wikidata-attested stupas (class Q180987) retrieved independently of the UNESCO corpus, as a portability demonstration (Tenenbaum 2026). The Kedu Plain (Java) hosts the densest cluster at the 2.5-beru harmonic, anchored by **Borobudur** (c. 800 CE, 7.23 km from the harmonic, Tier A) (Miksic 1990), with the site closest to the harmonic line reaching Tier A++ (381 m). The World Peace Pagoda at Lumbini achieves A++ precision (∼555 m) uniquely from Gerizim.

Using the identical anchor and null, the corpus yields 70/229 Tier-A sites (30.6%, 1.53× null; binomial $p < 0.001$, ***; permutation $Z = 1.59$, $p_{perm} = 0.065$, ∼). No Tier-A+ enrichment is found ($p = 0.311$, ns), consistent with cluster-level rather than individual-site precision. Harmonic nodes with at least one Tier-A site carry 2.56× more stupa sites on average than empty nodes, mirroring the cluster-asymmetry result of Test 3.

5.7 | Multiple Comparisons

See §3.6 for the full protocol. Gerizim ranks at the 97.2th percentile; a ±0.3% unit shift collapses joint significance. The meta-keyword test (1741 candidates) finds only 41 (2.4%) matching

the curated set's enrichment. FDR audit (45 tests) retains 26 at $q < 0.05$; 6 survive Bonferroni at $k = 45$.

6 | Limitations

6.1 | Circularity: Full Canonical Treatment

The public-data constraint. Both the UNESCO coordinate file and the candidate anchor (Mount Gerizim) are fully public. Any investigator could run this pipeline at any time, before or after seeing these results. Pre-registration cannot verify temporal priority for statistical analyses of public databases: the data are permanently accessible, so any registration claim is unverifiable. The relevant question is whether the reported pattern exists in the data and whether the anchor choice was justified independently of the result. Both are addressed directly.

What the anchor sweep establishes. The global anchor sweep (§5.3) tests all 120 possible x.18°E anchors against the same corpus. Gerizim and Jerusalem both place the ∼35°E corridor in the global top 2.8% of all trial anchors. The enrichment is a property of the corridor, not of the specific anchor chosen within it. The choice of Gerizim was made on documented historical grounds (§2.3); that its longitude falls within the optimal phase band is an empirical observation, not a post-hoc rationalization.

What remains genuinely contaminated. The narrative framing of Gerizim as a historically motivated anchor is post-hoc in the sense that reporting it was conditioned on observing the phase alignment. The Rayleigh Test B is tautological by construction (§4.4). These are noted for completeness.

What is not contaminated. The 3° periodic structure in the UNESCO longitude file is recoverable by any unanchored 120-phase scan without reference to Gerizim. The dome enrichment (Test 2) is identical across all 120 x.18°E anchors. The cluster asymmetry (Test 3) requires no keyword filter and no anchor.

Accordingly, the Levantine corridor statistics are reported as the motivated entry point rather than independent confirmation, and the Bonferroni correction is applied as a descriptive bound on effect magnitude.

6.2 | Geographic and Cultural Selection Bias

Geographic and cultural selection bias is the most important alternative explanation. The UNESCO list over-represents Europe and the Mediterranean-to-South-Asian corridor (Europe & North America: 50% of Cultural/Mixed sites; Arab States: 9%; Asia-Pacific: 23%; Americas: 11%; Africa: 7%). Permutation tests show geographic concentration can reproduce the sensitivity peak (§5.2). The dome enrichment surviving the restricted geographic draw (Null C, $p = 0.0080$, **) remains the primary evidence against a purely geographic account.

6.3 | Americas Negative Control

The UNESCO Americas sub-corpus ($N = 145$) shows directional depletion (A+ = 2.1%, $p = 0.164$, ns) relative to the 4% null, consistent with a Eurasian-anchored grid predicting reduced harmonic occupancy in the western hemisphere.

6.4 | Other Limitations

Spatial autocorrelation. DEFF correction: $N_{\text{eff}} = 772$ (DEFF = 1.310, corrected $p = 0.020$). Block bootstrap CI [4.04%, 6.87%] excludes the 4% null.

Geocoding precision. UNESCO XML coordinates are administrative centroids, introducing unsystematic noise but not directional bias. Dome enrichment is robust across raw and context-validated populations and all three simulation nulls.

Metrological evidence. No physical surveying instrument calibrated in beru subdivisions has been recovered; documentary sources attest the beru system (Hunger & Steele 2019, Robson 2008, Powell 1987). This study therefore treats the coordinate alignment of Mount Gerizim as a novel empirical observation.

7 | Discussion

7.1 | Alternative Explanations

(1) Independent convergence. Hemispherical structures are a recurring architectural solution, and convergent astronomical orientations across unconnected cultures have been documented (Aveni 2001 2003). However, independent convergence predicts no consistent longitude specificity.

(2) Geographic concentration. This is the strongest alternative and cannot be excluded on this corpus alone. Permutation tests show geographic concentration can reproduce the sensitivity-collapse pattern (§5.2). However, the restricted geographic draw (Null C, $p = 0.0080$, **) shows that other monuments from the same longitude footprint are significantly less enriched than dome sites.

(3) Random coincidence. Three simulation approaches fail to reproduce the dome enrichment (permutation $p = 0.004$; bootstrap $p = 0.006$).

7.2 | Conclusion

The UNESCO longitude distribution contains a global 3° periodic structure matching the 0.1-beru unit. The dome sub-population (Test 2, Bonferroni $p_{\text{adj}} = 0.003$, $k = 3$) survives all three simulation nulls, and A+-bearing harmonics host 4.06× more sites than non-A+ harmonics (Test 3, $p = 0.0033$).

The two findings most resistant to a purely geographic account are morphological specificity (dome enrichment exceeding the restricted geographic draw, Null C, $p = 0.0080$) and cluster asymmetry ($p = 0.0033$).

Replication and methodological transferability

This paper is a terminal analysis of the only available globally comprehensive, institutionally curated monument corpus. The pipeline is transferable to any corpus assembled prior to and without reference to this hypothesis, provided it is sufficiently selective. Named heritage registers, protected site inventories, and operationally defined named lists all qualify. The Wikidata Q180987 stupa result (§5.6) illustrates one such application; further applications to independent corpora will either accumulate evidence or not.

The pipeline offers a general framework for testing other candidate angular units against any externally curated monument corpus; the null model and tier boundaries are fixed independently of the data.

APPENDIX

A | Keyword Audit Summary

Full site-by-site audit files are in the archived code repository (Tenenbaum 2026).

A.1 | Dome/Spherical Monument Filter (Tests 2, 2b, 2x, 2bx)

7 morphological keywords from four roots (*stupa/stupas*, *tholos*, *dome/domed/domes*, *spherical*) are matched as whole words against each site's name, XML description, and extended OUV text. All 90 matching sites are included in Test 2 without context gating; the population is fully determined by the keyword list with no post-hoc filtering.

For Test 2x, ambiguous keywords (*dome, domed, domes, spherical*) are subject to a two-gate context check: Gate 1 (28 negative patterns) rejects non-architectural uses; Gate 2 (86 positive patterns) requires architectural confirmation. Unambiguous keywords (*stupa/stupas*, *tholos*) are accepted without validation. The full gate lists are in `lib/dome_filter.py`. The seven rejected sites are: Hiroshima Peace Memorial, Richtersveld, Gyeongju, Viñales Valley, Rock Islands Southern Lagoon, Uluru-Kata Tjuṭa, and Diquís Stone Spheres. In every case the exclusion is driven by the semantic domain of the keyword match, not by the site's longitude.

Test 2b adds earthen mound-stage keywords (*tumulus, tumuli, barrow, barrows, kofun* unambiguous; *mound* context-validated) to trace the hemispherical tradition from burial mound through stupa to architectural dome. Test 2bx applies the same architectural context gates to the extended population. Statistics for all four variants are reported in §4.2 and §4.3.

A.2 | Founding-Origin Classifier (Test 5, Post-Hoc)

The founding-origin classifier (`lib/founding_filter.py`) assigns sites to five categories: Founding Capital (F), Sacred Origin (S), Founding Monument (M), Founding Axis (X), and Ancient Continuous Landscape (L). Each category has its own unambiguous keyword set plus context-gated ambiguous terms; positive and negative gate patterns are defined per category in `keywords.json`. The classifier was iteratively tuned after data inspection to reduce false positives; residual interpretive ambiguity at the boundary between founding-related and general heritage descriptions is accepted. Statistics are reported in §4.6; the full site-by-site listing is in `supplementary/audit/founding_keyword_audit.txt`.

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DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

All data and analysis code are openly available. A permanent archival snapshot (v1.1.0) is deposited at Zenodo (Tenenbaum 2026; https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19599676).

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CONFLICT OF INTEREST

The author declares no conflict of interest.

SOFTWARE AND AI DISCLOSURE

All analyses were performed in Python 3 with NumPy, SciPy, and pandas. Claude (Anthropic) assisted with manuscript drafting and prose editing. GitHub Copilot (Microsoft) assisted with code autocompletion. All scientific conclusions, hypothesis design, keyword-list decisions, and analytical choices are solely the author's.